Gold standard annotation guidelines

Version 2 — 9 October 2026

Version 1 (frozen on 8 October 2026) did not cover several cases that the annotation treated as positive. Version 2 describes the criteria actually applied to the 145 gold episodes; the annotations themselves were not changed.

Principles

- The whole episode is annotated.
- Judge with what was public at that moment. No prices, no later facts.
- Guiding question: does the episode signal that the conflicts affecting crude supply are moving toward resolution or toward escalation?
- The conflicts that matter are those involving oil producers and routes: Iran and the Strait of Hormuz, Venezuela, Russia and Ukraine, the Houthis and the Red Sea.
- Novelty is not judged: the `novelty` feature already measures it.

Direction (−2 ... +2)

Positive = toward resolution: the war ending or won, an agreement, routes and oil flows reopened. Negative = toward escalation.

1. Does it say anything about where these conflicts are heading? No → **0**.
2. Sign:
   - **Positive**: ceasefires; deals and negotiations making progress; attacks called off or postponed; the United States controlling or reopening the Strait of Hormuz, oil flowing; claims that the war is won, the enemy defeated or the conflict over; envoys, meetings and trade agreements aimed at peace or involving oil purchases; sanctions or pressure presented together with a demand for an immediate ceasefire.
   - **Negative**: attacks launched or announced; ultimatums and threats; blockades; sanctions and tariffs on producers or on buyers of their oil; leaders killed; talks breaking down or hard-line positions; statements that Iran will never have a nuclear weapon.
3. Strength: **±2** for decisive moments: a war starting or ending, a ceasefire agreed, a major attack launched or imminent, a leader killed, a blockade imposed, the Strait of Hormuz declared open with oil flowing, a deal reached or major concessions obtained; also strong claims that the war is won and oil will flow. **±1** for everything else: talks, threats, demands, commentary.

Mixed messages: the decisive element prevails. If they balance out, judge the overall tone.

Intensity (1 ... 3)

- **1** → comment, opinion, forecast, claim
- **2** → threat, ultimatum, demand, intention
- **3** → action done, or imminent with a precise moment ("tonight", "within 48 hours")

Specificity (0 / 1)

1 if the episode is about a concrete action, threat or measure aimed at a precise target (a country, leader, group, place, facility or ship), or contains a quantity or a deadline. **0** for commentary, claims and generic statements, even when they name a country or a leader.
Convention: if `direction` = 0, then `intensity` = 1 and `specificity` = 0.

Always 0

- Actor or mechanism mentioned in passing in a post about something else.
- Polls; op-eds and articles that only argue with critics or the media. An article that reports an action is judged on the action.
- Arguments about past decisions or with opponents that say nothing about how the conflict is going.
- Military facts unrelated to oil producers or routes (drug-trafficking boats, drones over Poland).
- Comments on prices that have already moved.
- Greenland.

Examples

episode	dir	int	spec
"Complete and Total CEASEFIRE (in approximately 6 hours…)"	+2	3	1
"Oil is flowing like never before… the Strait of Hormuz is open"	+2	2	1
"Iran has officially responded… very weak response… 14 missiles"	+1	3	1
"very close to meeting our objectives as we consider winding down"	+1	2	1
"the nuclear sites in Iran are completely destroyed" (argument with CNN)	+1	1	1
"Countries that receive Oil through the Hormuz Strait must take care of that passage, and we will help"	+1	2	1
"Secondary Tariff on the Country of Venezuela"	−1	1	1
"Iran must stop the sending of these Supplies" (Houthis)	−1	2	1
"WE WILL NOT ALLOW ANY ENRICHMENT" (negotiation under way)	−1	2	1
Nigeria, "guns-a-blazing"	−1	1	0
"Khamenei… is dead"	−2	3	1
"If I didn't terminate… JCPOA"	0	1	0

Procedure

1. Trial on 20 episodes, revise, freeze, start again from scratch.
2. Random order, not chronological.
3. Every doubt in `notes`.
4. The 50 double episodes to a second person. Target: weighted kappa ≥ 0.6 on direction.
5. Check: episodes labelled 0 in the rule versions must have `direction` 0.